

Sixth Sunday After Pentecost

Dominica Sexta Post Pentecosten

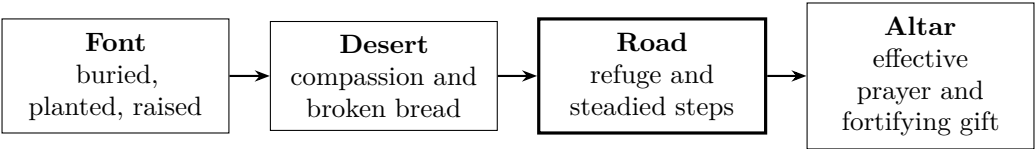
TLM propers: the baptized are buried, fed, steadied, and fortified

Proper	TLM text / reference	Scriptural axis	Connection
Introit	<i>Dominus fortitudo plebis suae</i> (Ps. 27:8–9)	Strength for God's people	God enters as strength and saving protector of a people whom he blesses and rules.
Collect	<i>Deus virtutum</i> : increase religion; nourish and guard the good	Growth in grace	The new life requires God both to implant love of his name and preserve what grace begins.
Epistle	Rom. 6:3–11	Buried with Christ; newness of life	Baptism gives participation in Christ's death and resurrection, not advice for renovating the old man.
Gradual	<i>Convertere, Domine; Domine, refugium factus es nobis</i> (Ps. 89:13, 1)	The Lord's return and refuge	The newly alive answer the Epistle by asking the Lord to return and by confessing him as their refuge.
Alleluia	<i>In te, Domine, speravi</i> (Ps. 30:2–3)	Trust and deliverance	Trust in God's inclined ear prepares the assembly to hear why Christ will not send the hungry away fasting.
Gospel	Mark 8:1–9	Christ feeds the four thousand	Christ's compassion supplies a people who cannot sustain themselves on the way.
Offertory	<i>Perfice gressus meos</i> (Ps. 16:5–7)	Steady steps in God's paths	The baptized life becomes an offered walk whose steps still require divine keeping.
Secret	<i>Propitiare, Domine, supplicationibus nostris ... nullius sit irritum votum, nullius vacua postulatio ... quod fideliter petimus, efficaciter consequamur</i>	Faithful prayer made effective	God is asked to receive his people's oblations, let no vow or petition be empty, and bring faithful asking to effective fulfillment.
Communion	<i>Circumibo et immolabo</i> (Ps. 26:6)	Sacrifice of jubilation	At the altar, received mercy returns to God as praise and jubilant sacrifice.
Postcommunion	<i>Repleti sumus, Domine, muneribus tuis</i>	Cleansing and aid	God's gifts are asked to cleanse by their effect and fortify by their help.

Sense	Synthesis
Literal	Romans 6 says that the baptized have been buried with Christ and must reckon themselves dead to sin; Mark 8 recounts Christ's compassionate feeding of a hungry multitude.
Allegorical	Baptism joins the Church to Christ's paschal death and life. Augustine reads the loaves as scriptural and spiritual nourishment; in the wider canonical and liturgical tradition, the multiplication also prefigures the superabundance of the Eucharist.
Moral	The Christian must refuse the old servitude, walk in the grace already given, confess dependence, and receive rather than pretend to be self-sustaining.
Anagogical	Christ keeps his pilgrim people from failing on the road and directs them toward the final feast, where resurrection life is no longer threatened by sin, hunger, or death.

Font, Desert, Road, and Altar

This Sunday does not place baptism, the multiplication of bread, and Eucharistic offering beside one another as isolated themes. It follows a people whom God has made alive and must still sustain. The Epistle carries them through Christ’s death at the font; the Gospel finds them hungry in the desert; the chants ask that they not fail on the road; the altar receives their steps and prayer; Communion and Postcommunion turn gift into praise, cleansing, and strength.



Editorial mystagogical synthesis. The four-stage itinerary is this guide’s reading of the appointed formulary. The Fathers below directly expound Romans, Mark, or Psalm 26, or illuminate sacramental doctrine; none is being claimed as an expositor of this Roman formulary as a whole.

A people lives by received strength
The Introit names the Lord as the strength, saving protector, blessing, and ruler of his people. The Collect keeps that agency before every later command: God gives love of his Name, increases religion, nourishes the good, and guards what he has nourished. Baptismal life is real life, but never self-originating or self-sustaining life.

Romans 6: Baptismal Fact and Baptismal Task

Paul’s sequence begins with incorporation before exhortation. The baptized have entered Christ’s death, been buried with him, and received a new principle of life. Only then does Paul command a new walk and a truthful reckoning. Present moral renewal and future bodily resurrection are joined without being collapsed.

Paul’s phrase	Sacramental fact	Present demand	Future horizon
Baptized into Christ’s death	Baptism joins the person to the once-for-all death of Christ; it is not advice to imitate a distant example.	Sin’s former claim cannot be treated as the baptized person’s defining identity.	The one who died and rose will die no more; his resurrection grounds Christian hope.
Buried with him	The old life is placed under Christ’s paschal burial.	“Walk in newness” requires embodied conduct corresponding to the gift already received.	Burial tends toward resurrection, not merely toward a revised moral record.
Planted together in the likeness of death	The agricultural image suggests incorporation capable of bearing fruit.	Righteousness, sanctification, and adoption must become visible fruit rather than an honorary title.	Paul promises belonging to Christ’s resurrection itself, not only a present analogy.
The old man crucified	The “old man” names the regime and totality of wickedness, not the substance of the body or created human nature.	Servitude to sin is broken so that obedience no longer belongs to the former master.	The destruction of death’s dominion appears first in Christ and finally in those who live with him.
Reckon yourselves dead to sin, alive to God	The imperative recognizes what grace has accomplished and calls for judgment according to that reality.	Christian agency is summoned, but specifically “in Christ Jesus,” with the risen Lord as ally.	The present reckoning anticipates the unveiled life that baptism promises.

On Romans 6:2–13 Chrysostom distinguishes Christ’s bodily death from the baptized person’s real death to sin. Former transgressions are buried by gift; continued mortification requires earnest human cooperation, yet with abundant divine help. “Planted together” bears present fruit in righteousness, sanctification, and adoption and points beyond them to bodily resurrection. The body is not the old man and is not evil; the old man is wickedness whose rule baptism breaks.

Three orders that must remain together

Indicative: God has joined the baptized to Christ. **Imperative:** therefore walk and reckon according to that gift. **Petition:** the Collect, Offertory, Secret, and Postcommunion ask God to nourish, steady, fulfill, cleanse, and fortify that walk. Removing the indicative produces moralism; removing the imperative produces inert sacramentalism; removing petition imagines that grace is needed only at the beginning.

Cyril and Ambrose: What the Font Gives

The fourth-century mystagogues speak to the newly baptized after the rites. They do not reduce the font to a visual reminder. At the same time, they carefully distinguish Christ’s historical, bodily Pasch from the sacramental mode by which believers participate in it.

Witness and locus	Mystagogical account	Reality communicated	Boundary retained
St. Cyril of Jerusalem, <i>Mystagogical Catechesis II.4–8</i>	The threefold descent and ascent follows confession of Father, Son, and Holy Ghost and images Christ’s three-day burial. The same water is grave and mother.	The rite is likeness in mode, yet salvation and fellowship in Christ’s sufferings are real gifts; dying and birth coincide sacramentally.	Christ actually died, was buried, and rose bodily. The baptized does not repeat that event or undergo the same physical subject of death.
St. Ambrose, <i>On the Mysteries 19–21, 28</i>	Water, Spirit, Cross, and the Trinitarian Name bury wickedness and bring forth resurrection to God. Visible water must be read through divine presence and operation.	The font effects regeneration rather than merely representing a decision already complete.	Divine working does not make the baptized incapable of later infidelity; Ambrose immediately joins gift to a rule of life.
St. Ambrose, <i>On the Mysteries 41–43</i>	The Spirit’s seal is to be preserved in faith and works; the cleansed people then hastens from the font to Christ’s altar and heavenly feast.	Baptismal identity is inherently Eucharistic and ecclesial: the regenerated are led toward sacramental nourishment.	This supplies a genuine font-to-altar mystagogy, not direct commentary on Mark’s multiplication or this Sunday’s ordering.

The Collect’s verbs fit the mystagogical order. God has begun a real good; therefore the Church asks him to increase religion, nourish the good, and preserve what he nourishes. Cyril’s grave-and-mother image prevents both nostalgia and presumption: the font is an accomplished birth whose life must grow.

Mark 8: Compassion in the Desert

The literal event controls every further reading. A real crowd has remained with Jesus for three days in a deserted place. They have nothing to eat. Christ knows that sending them away fasting would make them collapse on the journey, receives the available loaves, gives thanks, breaks, distributes through the disciples, feeds all, and leaves seven baskets. Bodily hunger and divine compassion are not disposable scenery for allegory.

Feature in Mark	Bede, <i>In Marcum</i> II.32	Augustine, <i>Sermon</i> 45.1–3	Interpretive limit
Christ's compassion and power	Bede sees in the one Redeemer truly human sympathy for the multitude and divine power in feeding four thousand.	Augustine begins from the accomplished wonder and asks hearers to receive its intelligible speech.	Christological and spiritual readings intensify rather than deny the material feeding.
Bread broken and given through disciples	For Bede, breaking opens the mysteries; apostolic ministry distributes the food of life to the Church.	Augustine compares scriptural exposition to bread broken from a common heavenly store shared by preacher and hearer.	Both primarily interpret nourishment by the Word; neither passage is direct Eucharistic exegesis of Mark 8.
Seven loaves and seven baskets	Bede associates the loaves with the Spirit's sevenfold grace and the remaining abundance with higher or still-unfolded teaching.	Augustine reads seven as the Spirit's complete operation and the baskets as the Church's fullness.	Numerical readings are patristic allegory, not replacements for seven actual loaves and baskets in the narrative.
Four thousand	The multitude manifests the ecclesial reach of the food distributed through apostolic ministry.	Augustine connects four thousand with the Church founded upon the fourfold Gospel.	The ecclesial number-symbolism must remain subordinate to Christ's concrete mercy toward the whole hungry crowd.

Bede's source status

Bede's Latin commentary survives in *In Marci Evangelium Expositio* II.32. The English formulations used here are cautiously paraphrased from the later *Catena Aurea*, which preserves excerpts. They are not presented as a checked translation of Bede's complete Latin discussion.

The Gospel's liturgical placement permits a Eucharistic horizon, but it does not make every patristic bread interpretation Eucharistic. Bede and Augustine directly emphasize opened Scripture, apostolic distribution, the Spirit, and the Church. Ambrose will supply explicit Eucharistic doctrine at the altar; the movement from the desert feeding to Communion is an editorial synthesis enacted by this Mass.

The Road: Grace Does Not Send the Hungry Away

The Gospel names the danger: the people may faint *on the way*. The surrounding chants make that road audible. The Gradual asks the Lord to return and confesses him as refuge; the Alleluia hopes in his inclined ear; the Offertory asks him to perfect the worshipper's steps in his paths. Baptismal resurrection does not remove pilgrimage, exhaustion, or dependence.

Patristic witness	Reading of "lest they faint on the way"	Contribution here
St. Gregory the Great, <i>Moralia</i> I.19, preserved in the <i>Catena Aurea</i>	The preached word must supply consolation, lest people hungry for truth sink under the toil of this life.	Bede's opened scriptural bread becomes provision for endurance, not information detached from the road.
St. Ambrose, <i>Exposition of Luke</i> VI.73, preserved in the <i>Catena Aurea</i>	The good Lord requires diligence and gives strength; he distributes to all, while the hearer must extend a hand to receive.	Divine provision and real reception are not rivals. The pilgrim acts because compassion supplies what action needs.
Bede, <i>In Marcum</i> II.32	Those "from afar" can signify lives that have wandered far in sin and return through repentance; the food of life is distributed through the Church.	No distance becomes a reason for Christ to dismiss the returning person fasting.

The Offertory answers Paul's "walk"

Perfice gressus meos in semitis tuis does not offer an already flawless journey. It places actual steps beneath divine action: perfect or steady them in your paths, incline your ear, and show mercy. The one buried with Christ still learns how resurrection life walks.

The Secret: Faithful Asking and Effective Fulfillment

The Secret is the hinge between the road's unfinished steps and Communion's jubilant sacrifice. It asks God to receive the people's oblations and to keep every vow and petition from emptiness. Its final clause requires a theological guardrail: effectual fulfillment cannot mean that intensity of belief guarantees every temporal outcome requested.

Latin hinge	Immediate petition	Question it raises
<i>has oblationes populi tui benignus assume</i>	God is asked mercifully to receive the oblations of his people.	The prayer's efficacy begins in divine reception, not in a human technique.
<i>nullius sit irritum votum</i>	May no one's vow be void, frustrated, or without effect.	How is a vowed good purified when the one who vows understands it imperfectly?
<i>nullius vacua postulatio</i>	May no one's petition be empty.	Is a denied temporal request necessarily empty, or can mercy answer more deeply than the requested form?
<i>quod fideliter petimus, efficaciter consequamur</i>	May what the Church faithfully asks be obtained with real effect.	What makes asking faithful, and what counts as its divinely intended effect?

St. Augustine — *Letter 130 to Proba*, 15–18, 21–29

Augustine is not commenting on this Secret. He supplies doctrinal control for its strongest verbs. Prayer exercises and enlarges the desire by which the worshipper can receive God's immense gift; words recall, test, and rekindle that desire. Faith, hope, charity, and the Lord's Prayer govern what is asked. Temporal goods may be sought in relation to the one blessed life with God, but the Christian often does not know whether a particular relief will help or harm. God may mercifully deny what Paul asked and may grant an impatient request as judgment. The certain final object is life with God; every lesser petition is effectual only within that order.

What *fideliter* cannot mean

Faithful asking is not confidence that God must ratify the petitioner's preferred scenario. It is prayer formed by faith, hope, charity, the Lord's Prayer, and submission to the good God's will actually gives. A temporal refusal may therefore be an efficacious answer, while the Holy Spirit enlarges and redirects desire toward the unfailing final good.

The Secret also looks backward and forward. It receives the *people's* oblations, the same people whom the Introit calls God's inheritance and whom Christ feeds as a multitude. It asks for effect, and the Postcommunion will use causal language again: may the gifts cleanse by their operation and fortify by their aid.

Communion: The Sacrifice of Jubilation

The Communion antiphon takes Psalm 26:6: "I have gone about, and have sacrificed in his tabernacle a sacrifice of jubilation; I will sing and give praise to the Lord." Augustine's *Exposition on Psalm 26*, 6 is direct interpretation of that appointed verse, although not of its later Communion placement.

St. Augustine — *Exposition on Psalm 26, 6*

Augustine reads the going-about as faith's world-embracing confession of Christ. The sacrifice of rejoicing praises God for the Son's humility in time and sounds in both heart and deed. This is a sacrifice of praise, not yet an explicit Eucharistic exposition. At Communion, the formulary itself places that praise upon sacramental reception.

Ambrose's *On the Mysteries* 43–55 supplies the explicit altar doctrine. The cleansed people hastens to the heavenly feast; the gift is Christ's Body and Blood, made by Christ's consecrating word; the communicant's "Amen" joins interior faith to spoken confession. Christ feeds the Church through sacraments that strengthen the soul and demand integrity of life. Ambrose is not commenting on Psalm 26 or Mark 8 here, but his mystagogy makes the font-to-altar movement doctrinally concrete.

Completion	Patristic illumination	Ongoing effect
Psalmic praise	Augustine joins jubilation to Christ's humility, heart, and deed.	Communion must become a lived sacrifice of thanksgiving, not a sound detached from the renewed walk.
Eucharistic gift	Ambrose identifies what the altar gives as Christ's Body and Blood and treats the "Amen" as confession of the heart.	The traveler receives Christ, not merely encouragement to continue by natural strength.
Postcommunion petition	The Roman prayer asks that received gifts cleanse by their effect and fortify by their help.	Fullness at the altar does not end dependence; sacramental effect prepares the baptized for continued resistance, growth, and journey.

A patristic listening sequence for the Mass

1. At the Introit and Collect, hear a people receive strength, rule, implanted love, growth, nourishment, and preservation before it speaks of its own resolve.
2. In Romans, keep fact, task, and hope together. With Chrysostom, distinguish Christ's bodily death, baptismal death to sin, present moral fruit, and future resurrection.
3. At the Gradual and Alleluia, let the newly alive remain refuge-seeking and dependent. Resurrection life does not make prayer obsolete.
4. In the Gospel, preserve the hungry bodies and Christ's compassion. Then hear Bede and Augustine on opened Scripture, apostolic distribution, the Spirit's fullness, and the Church.
5. On the road to the altar, join Paul's "walk," Mark's danger of fainting, and the Offertory's unsteady steps without claiming that a Father composed the sequence.
6. In the Secret, ask Augustine's questions of desire: is the petition formed by faith, hope, charity, the Lord's Prayer, and the final good, or does it demand control of a temporal outcome?
7. At Communion, let Augustine's sacrifice of jubilation meet Ambrose's explicit Eucharistic mystagogy; in the Postcommunion, ask that Christ's gift cleanse and fortify the continuing journey.

Source boundaries to retain

- Chrysostom on Romans 6, Bede and Augustine on Mark 8, and Augustine on Psalm 26 are **direct patristic exegesis** of appointed biblical texts, though not commentaries on this Roman formulary.
- Bede's English material comes through excerpting in the later *Catena Aurea*; the Latin locus is identified separately. Gregory and Ambrose on the road are also cited as **patristic excerpts preserved in the Catena**.
- Cyril and Ambrose on baptism and Eucharist, and Augustine's *Letter 130* on prayer, are **sacramental or doctrinal illumination**. Augustine does not directly expound the Secret.
- The font-desert-road-altar itinerary and the Eucharistic application of the feeding and psalm are **editorial liturgical syntheses** controlled by the actual proper texts.

Primary References

- *Missale Romanum* (1962), *Dominica Sexta post Pentecosten*, Introit through Postcommunion; local OCR temporal corpus identified in the README. Latin OCR remains subject to printed-missal verification; psalm numbering follows the Vulgate.
- Holy Scripture: Romans 6:3–14; Mark 8:1–9; Psalms 27, 89, 30, 16, and 26 in Vulgate numbering.
- St. John Chrysostom, *Homily 10 on Romans*, on 6:2–4, working public-domain text; *Homily 11 on Romans*, on 6:5–14, working public-domain text.
- St. Cyril of Jerusalem, *Mystagogical Catechesis II* (Catechetical Lecture 20), 4–8, working public-domain text.
- St. Ambrose, *On the Mysteries* 19–21, 28, 41–55, 58–59, font, seal, altar, and Eucharistic effect.
- St. Bede, *In Marci Evangelium Expositio* II.32, PL 92:205B–208D, public-domain Latin text; selected English excerpts in St. Thomas Aquinas, *Catena Aurea* on Mark 8.
- St. Augustine, *Sermon 45* (95 in the Benedictine series), 1–3, on Mark 8:5, working public-domain text.
- St. Gregory the Great, *Moralia* I.19, and St. Ambrose, *Exposition of Luke* VI.73, excerpts at Mark 8:3 in the *Catena Aurea*.
- St. Augustine, *Letter 130 to Proba*, 15–18, 21–29, desire, faithful prayer, and submission to God's answer; *Exposition on Psalm 26*, 6, sacrifice of jubilation. New Advent's psalm page heading uses Psalm 27.